



A COZY ROGUELITE POINT-&-CLICK ADVENTURE

# Festival of Souls

*What does it mean to belong — and does connection span lifetimes?*

GAME DESIGN SUMMARY

*in the spirit of Outer Wilds · Spiritfarer · Frieren*

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GAME DESIGN SUMMARY

## The Concept

Festival of Souls is a cozy roguelite **point-and-click adventure** — *Outer Wilds* meets *Spiritfarer* meets *Frieren* — where you explore, collect, and discover in a hand-painted magical world.

*The game explores one question: what does it mean to belong, and does connection span lifetimes?*

**The hook.** Once a year, the **Lantern Arch** lights the way for souls to return so their loved ones can remember them. That's what the whole town spends the week building toward.

You play a mage who has just arrived in town before the Festival of Souls. You forage, craft, learn folk magic, and get to know your neighbors — and your choices shape how the festival turns out. One life unfolds across many festivals: your home fills, your bonds deepen, the town grows familiar. When you start a **new life**, the souls return with shuffled roles — the blacksmith may now be the postman — but each soul's core personality stays fixed, and the bonds you built carry forward.

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GAME DESIGN SUMMARY

## What Makes It Different

Most "cozy roguelites" are cozy paint over a tension engine — they keep death-as-punishment or push-your-luck and just make it *look* soft. This game inverts the mechanics themselves, keeping each pillar's structure but re-tuning it to produce warmth instead of tension.

### No permadeath

A life ends in a festival or a chosen new life — the harshest roguelite mechanic becomes an elective reincarnation. Nothing is lost, only lived.

### No procedural danger

Reshuffles re-deal *roles* (personality fixed), so novelty reads as reunion and rediscovery — never threat.

### Knowledge, not power

Like *Outer Wilds*, nothing mechanically unlocks — you carry forward *knowing more*, plus the bonds and collection you've built.

### Escalating intimacy

Bonds deepen, dialogue warms, and the festival grows grander with depth — instead of harder.

### Discovery over optimization

You find spells and folk magic; the reward is discovery itself, without build-optimization stress.



## Core Loop

Four verbs drive everything:

### Collect

Forage components, mementos, and sounds from the world.

### Make

Combine components and knowledge into a spell, dish, or craft.

### Use

Apply an item or spell to a target — the target decides the result.

### Converse

Talk with an NPC; no object changes hands, just dialogue.

A day runs **morning** → **afternoon** → **evening** on a move budget. You carry a satchel and a notebook; the notebook holds everything you've learned and never expires. At day's end you bank what fits in the satchel and return home — your hub for this life, which you decorate and which starts empty each new life.

A **festival cycle** is the week leading up to one festival night. Each NPC has a personal goal for the festival that you can help with, and the festival's outcome depends on how much you accomplished and who you bonded with.



## The Reshuffle — Essence vs. Role

Every soul is built on an **essence / role split**. The essence — a want plus a repeated behavior — never changes across lives. The role (their job in town) is re-dealt each new life from a shared pool: Mage, Blacksmith, Baker, Postman, Herbalist, Priest, Farmer.

That reshuffle is the payload, not a reskin: the same fixed want paired with a new civic role produces a genuinely different story each time — a soul whose want is "to be needed" plays very differently as the town's Baker than as its Priest. Name, gender, and personality stay fixed so you recognize each soul across lives; only their position changes. The roster is **3 deep souls** (hand-authored arcs) plus **5 texture souls**, each embodying a different theory of belonging — *earned, given, chosen, tended, or found*.

| SOUL                                                    | BELONGING-STANCE                                      | RECOGNITION HOOK                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The Keeper</b> — Mara ( <i>deep</i> )                | Tended — keeps the anchor from slipping into the past | Finds the beauty in what's passing               |
| <b>Toby, the Giver</b> ( <i>deep</i> )                  | Earned by being needed                                | Sees how people connect                          |
| <b>Ilsa, the Kinbound</b> ( <i>deep</i> )               | Given — blood, family above all                       | Gathers people to a table                        |
| <b>Nell, the Content Server</b> ( <i>texture</i> )      | Needed, and at peace with it (counters the Giver)     | Hums while working; never keeps score            |
| <b>Juno, the Found-Family Keeper</b> ( <i>texture</i> ) | Who you <i>choose</i> — the game's thesis             | Her "family" all found each other                |
| <b>Linnet, Half of a Pair</b> ( <i>texture</i> )        | The one bond out of reach — split by timing           | Keeps a habit for someone now married to another |
| <b>Pip, the Wonder-Seeker</b> ( <i>texture</i> )        | Belonging is in shared wonder                         | Drags people to see small marvels                |
| <b>Bex, the Rule-Breaker</b> ( <i>texture</i> )         | Says "you belong" plainly, where others deflect       | Names the feeling out loud                       |





## Magic System

Spells are learned by watching a neighbor cast (a clue, not the spell) and confirmed by doing. A spell is a **phrase plus components**, cast by selecting inventory items and entering the phrase. Anyone can cast — mana affects only *quality*, never whether you can cast at all.

**Outcomes are receiver-determined, not verb-determined.** The same spell produces different results depending on its target; the verb encodes only what was attempted, never what happens.

Proven end-to-end by running **ignite** against seven receivers through the actual narrative pipeline:

| RECEIVER                    | OUTCOME                      | REACTION                                                                  |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Stick                       | Catches                      | Catches at the tip and holds a small, steady flame.                       |
| Hedge                       | Catches, clears the obstacle | Burns along its dry inner branches; the flame opens the blocked path.     |
| Furnace                     | State-dependent              | Unlit & stocked: the banked fuel catches. Already lit: nothing changes.   |
| Bread                       | Scorches, doesn't catch      | The crust blackens and curls; the loaf is ruined, no flame catches.       |
| Cat                         | No physical effect           | The light washes over its fur and fades; it flattens, bolts, then grooms. |
| Toby ( <i>direct cast</i> ) | No physical effect           | "Save that for the oven."                                                 |
| Ilsa ( <i>direct cast</i> ) | No physical effect           | ( <i>null — no reaction</i> )                                             |



## Festival Outcome

Festival night isn't a win/lose branch — it's a **spectrum**, rendered through lighting, turnout, and who shows up, with a rare top tier reserved for exceptional depth.



### Quiet

A modest festival; a few souls, low warm light.



### Warm

The town turns out; the square fills, lanterns lit.



### Grand

The fullest turnout, the Lantern Arch at its brightest.



### Souls of the World

Rare top, at exceptional depth: the souls of the world appear.

The tier is driven by pairing each soul's fixed **want** against their re-dealt role's **civic goal** — tension or alignment between the two is what makes the same soul's story land differently life to life. Two tracks run in parallel and never collide: the **festival goal** (external, moves the tier) and the **soul's arc** (internal, moves nothing).

*A player who ignores every soul's inner life can still reach a Grand festival by finishing the town's collective work; a player who goes deep on one soul and nothing else gets a Quiet festival and a different story. Neither is the "right" way to play. There is no hard-lose — every festival ends with something, because **the game can't be lost, only lived**.*



## AI Pipeline & Token Budget

Content is produced by a crew of specialized agents under human review at every gate — agents generate volume and check consistency, but a human approves every line before it ships.

| AGENT                 | OUTPUT / RESPONSIBILITY                                                     | BUDGET |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Orchestrator          | Sequences the crew; collects typed output and surfaces the human gates      | 200K   |
| Narrative Director    | Surfaces lore, proposes arc-doc fields, drafts the arc doc for ratification | —      |
| Narrative Architect   | Persona cards, seed→payoff echo map, NPC codex of locked facts              | 300K   |
| Content / Dialogue    | All player-facing text — NPC lines, lore, descriptions                      | 700K   |
| Consistency Verifier  | Flags each batch against invariants + voice register (flags only)           | 300K   |
| QA / Playtest         | Verifies the slice is traversable — no soft-locks or dead-ends              | 250K   |
| Style / Art-Direction | Checks art against color grammar + silhouette rules; flags drift            | 100K   |
| Production / PM       | Tracks backlog, flags scheduling risk, weekly readiness summary             | 50K    |

**Budget assumption:** one chat's context is ~1M tokens; the project assumes a **3M total** — **2M** for the narrative/content crew and **1M reserved** for the technical track (Unreal integration).

### MEASURED, NOT ESTIMATED

| UNIT                                         | MEASURED | SCALES WITH            |
|----------------------------------------------|----------|------------------------|
| Architect — one soul's persona card + echoes | ~51K     | Souls (paid once each) |
| Content + Verifier — one soul in one scene   | ~107K    | Soul-appearances       |

Run for real on 2026-07-25 (27 agents, two phases): **cost scales by soul-appearances, not souls**. At 8 souls, persona cards cost ~411K, leaving ~1.59M for **~15 appearances** — about one per time-block across the 5-day × 3-block festival week, with zero revisions. A measured limit, not a design choice.



## Scope

The vertical slice targets: one playable week reaching festival night, one complete hand-authored deep-soul arc (seed to payoff), one hand-scripted on-camera reshuffle, and persistence of bond levels and collection across a new life. Built on **Ink** (prototyped in browser, carried into Unreal via ink-to-UE integration) with a Point-and-Click toolkit, Wwise audio, and static-camera 3D scenes — split into a narrative track and a visual/asset track so review never blocks asset work.

| TIER    | NARRATIVE                                                                | WORLD / LEVELS                                                                                   | AI PIPELINE                                                                          |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MUST    | 1 deep soul's arc end-to-end; one seed→payoff echo lands                 | Forest (1 + 2 unlocks) + Town (Square + 1 scene) + Festival; one week playable to festival night | Persistence + reshuffle work; Content + Consistency produce & check one soul's lines |
| SHOULD  | 3 deep souls' key lines authored & distinct; dialogue warms across lives | 3 festival tiers rendered; bond-driven change on a repeat reshuffle                              | Full crew runs; a second hand-authored reshuffle on camera                           |
| STRETCH | All 5 texture souls fully written; the souls-of-the-world top tier       | Extra forest screens; richer effects                                                             | Style/Art-Direction automated; Production/PM live; ink→UE integration spike          |

*The game cannot be lost, only lived.*

